There is a water quality emergency in India.

India's Environmental Laws Have a Broad Sweep

India participated in the first international environment conference in Stockholm in June 1972. Realizing that the state of the environment was fast deteriorating, the country decided to enact a law. The Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, referred to the decisions taken at the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment held in Stockholm and the need to implement these decisions insofar as they relate to the 'protection and improvement of environment and prevention of hazards to human beings, other living creatures, plants and property'.

The Environment Act, 1986, defines 'environment' widely to include 'water, air and land and the interrelationship which exists among and between water, air and land, and human beings, other living creatures, plants, micro-organism and property'. It also defines 'environmental pollutant' widely to mean 'any solid, liquid or gaseous substance present in such concentration as may be, or tend to be, injurious to environment'. The law treats 'the presence in the environment of any environmental pollutant' as environmental pollution. In a nutshell, any solid, liquid and gaseous substance present in water, air and land in such concentration that it is injurious to the natural state of relationship between water, air and land and human beings, other living creatures, plants, micro-organisms and property becomes environmental pollution.

The Environment Protection Act also deals with hazardous substances in quite a comprehensive manner.

The Act confers immense powers on the Central government. It empowers it 'to take all such measures as it deems necessary or expedient for the purpose of protecting and improving the quality of the environment and preventing, controlling and abating environment pollution'. The powers conferred are more extensive and intrusive than any other law has conferred